

Anabas testudineus

Climbing perch



Location S. and S.E. Asia

Length Up to 25 cm (10 in)
Weight Up to 150 g (5 oz)
Sex Male/Female
Status Data deficient



The climbing perch is a small freshwater fish, adapted to life in stagnant lakes and ponds where the oxygen supply is often poor. It gulps atmospheric oxygen at the surface of the water or climbs out to do so (see panel, right). In some areas, it buries itself in mud in the dry season. The climbing perch is a popular aquarium species, and is also sold as a food fish.

CLIMBING



The climbing perch will use the stiff spines on its gill covers and pectoral fins to "walk" from one body of water to another if forced to by very poor water conditions. It can survive out of water for several days at a time.

SPINY FINS

This small, stocky fish is uniformly gray, olive, or brown. Its fins are short, the dorsal and anal fins having prominent spines.

spiny dorsal fin

*Scophthalmus maximus*

Turbot



Location E. North Atlantic, Mediterranean, Black Sea

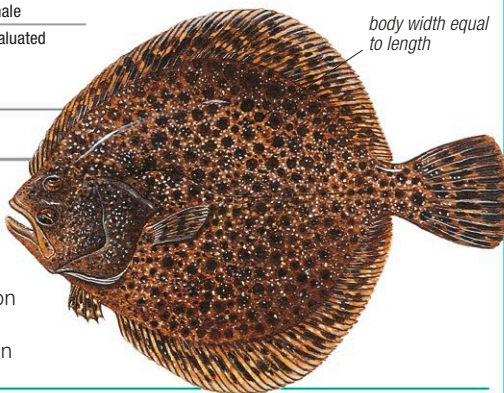
Length Up to 3¼ ft (1 m)
Weight Up to 55 lb (25 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated



The almost round body of this flatfish has a number of bony tubercles scattered over the surface of the upper side. Both the eyes are on the left side, and the mouth is asymmetrical, with teeth only on

the blind side. The jaws on the eyed side act like a siphon, drawing in water that is free of sand, thereby making respiration more efficient. One of the tastiest flatfish, this is an important commercial species.

body width equal to length

*Pleuronectes platessa*

European plaice



Location North Atlantic, Arctic, Mediterranean, Black Sea

Length Up to 3¼ ft (1 m)
Weight Up to 15 lb (7 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern



As a newly hatched fish larva, the European plaice lives for about 6 weeks near the surface of the sea. As in all flatfishes, a remarkable transformation then occurs that turns it into a bottom dweller. The left eye migrates across

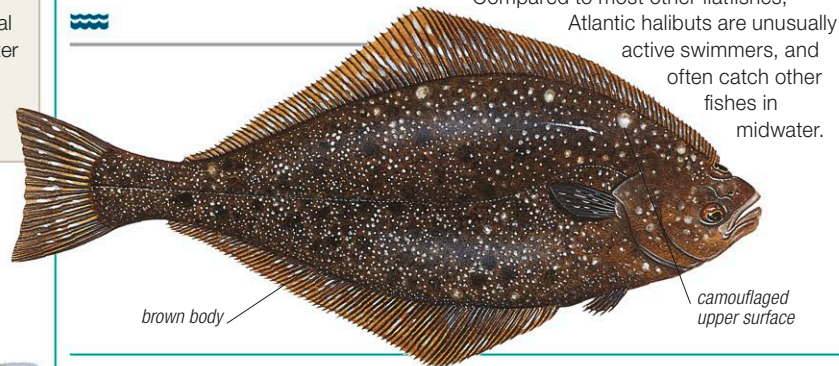
*Hippoglossus hippoglossus*

Atlantic halibut



Location North Atlantic, Arctic

Length Up to 8¼ ft (2.5 m)
Weight Up to 690 lb (315 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Endangered



brown body

camouflaged upper surface

Now endangered due to overfishing, the Atlantic halibut is one of the largest flatfishes—a group of over 700 species that have a highly distinctive anatomy, suiting them to life on the seabed. Instead of being flattened from top to bottom, like many seabed fishes, flatfishes are flattened sideways, but habitually lie on one side. The Atlantic halibut lies on its left side, and both its eyes are positioned facing upward, on its right. Compared to most other flatfishes, Atlantic halibuts are unusually active swimmers, and often catch other fishes in midwater.

Paralichthys dentatus

Summer flounder

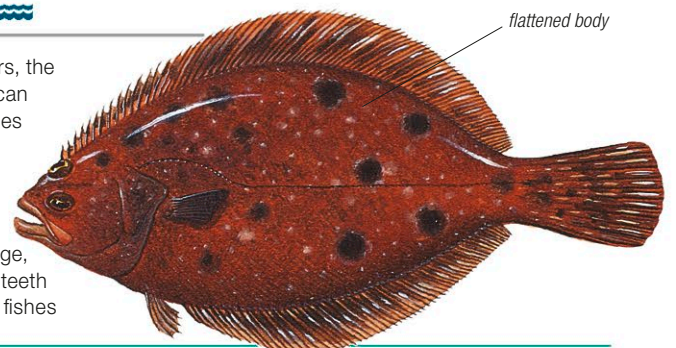


Location W. North Atlantic, E. North America

Length Up to 37 in (94 cm)
Weight Up to 26 lb (12 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern



Like other flounders, the summer flounder can tolerate low salinities and often enters estuaries. It is a bottom-dwelling predator that relies on camouflage, speed, and sharp teeth to catch the small fishes



flattened body

and other sea animals that make up its diet. The eggs of the summer flounder are covered in oil droplets; when the fish spawns, the eggs float up toward the surface, where they hatch into ordinary fish larvae. When a larva reaches about ½ in (1.5 cm) in length, its body becomes flattened and the right eye migrates to the left side. The larva, which lacks a swim bladder, then settles on the bottom.

Solea solea

Common sole



Location E. North Atlantic, Mediterranean, Black Sea

Length Up to 28 in (70 cm)
Weight Up to 66 lb (30 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Data deficient



A commercially important flatfish, the common sole lives in coastal and estuarine environments, where it rests on sandy and muddy sea beds. Like other flatfish, it is a highly asymmetrical animal, with both eyes on its colored right-hand side, which always faces upward as it swims or rests. The common sole is carnivorous, feeding preferentially on ragworms but also taking other worms, and molluscs. The blind side has a small tubular

nostril that helps it to detect such prey items by their scent. This allows the common sole to hunt under the cover of darkness and to lie still during the day, hidden by its extremely effective color camouflage. They will also frequently bury themselves just below the sediment surface with only their eyes visible. Common sole spawn in spring and summer in local spawning areas. The young remain in shallow bays and estuaries, which act as nursery areas. The Wadden Sea—a UNESCO world heritage site—is especially important.

